Mesa
SCHOOL OF BUSINESS

-1:0

Figuring out the Startup that you want to Build

PGP-How to Get and Evaluate Ideas

Built by alumni from

Northwestern Kellogg School of Management

Harvard Business School

Agenda

1. Where to look for compelling startup ideas
2. Five questions every founder should ask about their idea
3. Discussion on startups and examples from you



Where to look for compelling startup ideas







Start With Your Lived Pain

What have you struggled with so much that you'd build a company to fix it? The best ideas solve problems you've personally felt.

Spot Second-Order Effects of Shifts

New tech, regulation, or behavior unlocks second-order needs—ride the wave before others even see it coming.

Cross-Pollinate Proven Models Across Domains

Borrow ideas from one industry or context and apply them in a new one where they feel surprisingly fresh.

Reverse Pitch From Market or Channel

Start with a specific customer segment or distribution channel, then build what they need and can easily access.

Quick Quiz



Broke, needed rent—rented air mattresses during a conference. Discovered strangers would pay to stay in someone else's home.



Taught CAT exam prep to friends. His engaging style went viral. Turned into edtech platform combining content and tech.



Worked at WebEx. Knew video calls were bad. Rebuilt from scratch with focus on quality, speed, and stability.



Saw small sellers using WhatsApp to sell. Built tools to streamline orders, payments, and logistics.



Built a restaurant menu site after coworkers constantly asked for lunch options. Solved their own problem—others wanted it too.



Left finance for the internet gold rush. Started with stories on shelves. Mastered logistics. Built the rails for how the world shops.

Five questions every founder should ask



1. Who is my customer and what pain point am I solving?
2. Why is my product 10x better than the alternatives?
3. How much will my customers pay?
4. How many customers can my startup serve?
5. Why am I the right founder for this idea? Why is this the right time?

Market

Is there a deep unmet need in the world?

Product

Can you build a product that can address it?

Who are you looking to serve?

Anyone who enjoys biscuits—especially with tea, which is a daily ritual in the majority of Indian homes—is my target audience.

Urban millennials and Gen Z (ages 21–45) in India, socially active, curious about new experiences, and looking for convenient, premium alcohol options that reflect their culture and taste.

Our customer is the Indian middle-class, aged 18–40, who craves global food experiences but lacks access due to high costs, limited availability, and unfamiliarity with international cuisine.

If you had to sell your product to only one customer, who is that?
Be super specific (demographics + behavioral traits) and sharp.
Go after one segment (which one?).

What is the pain point that you want to solve?

Today, families are often overwhelmed by a fragmented home-care landscape — juggling between unverified nannies, unreliable nurses, and disjointed mental health resources, especially during high-stress moments like post-operative recovery or elder care. Last-minute emergencies and no-show caregivers only add to the emotional and logistical burden.

India's healthcare ecosystem suffers from a deep-rooted issue: the absence of a unified, lifelong health record system. Today, an individual's medical history is scattered across paper files, SMS reports, diagnostic slips, and disconnected hospital databases. There is no single, accessible repository that captures a person's health journey from birth to death. This fragmentation leads to repeated tests, missed diagnoses, and ineffective treatments.

Specific + High Consequence + Urgent (the pain is immediate) + High Frequency

What is the gap in the market?

Many prefer custom outfits that reflect their personal stories or align with the wedding theme. However, few brands offer truly personalized experiences for brides, grooms, and their families. There's a noticeable gap in the market for a convenient solution that allows customers to tailor every aspect of their attire — from selecting fabrics to choosing embroidery details.

Pet parents face challenges in managing their pets' health, training, nutritional needs due to fragmented solutions. This app creates an integrated ecosystem with AI-driven insights to optimise pet care, offering predictive health analysis, personalized recommendations and seamless access to essential services

How are you different from others in the market?
Are customers not happy with existing products? Why?
Why are players not able to solve this? Incentives? Capability?

Who is my customer and what pain point am I solving?

Who is your Ideal Customer Persona?	• You need to imagine and describe your customer in great detail • Demographics (Age, Gender, Income, Geography, Background) • Behavioral Traits (Aspirations, Beliefs, Risk Appetite)
Is there a real and deep pain point?	• Is your ICP disappointed with status quo? How do we know what? • Are they looking for alternatives? Are they leaving bad reviews? • What happens if problem is not solved? Is it urgent? Is it frequent?
Advice	• Avoid broad definitions; imagine your power use • Don't ask them if they will buy your product (unpack pain point) • 10 long open-ended interviews › › › 1000 Google Survey responses

Who is my customer and what pain point am I solving?

Startup	Bad Example	Good Example
Urban Company	All Indians living in urban areas	High-income urban millennials who value time, want trusted home services, and are tired of unreliable, low-quality local vendors.
kiwi	Democratize access to credit for all Indians	Digital-first salaried millennials (ages 24–35) in Tier 1 cities, earning ₹6–15L, seeking instant, app-based credit access without friction.

Why is my product 10x better than the alternatives?

Why is the problem not solved yet?	• What is the status quo? What are the alternatives? • Why are customers unhappy with alternatives? • Why are players not able to solve this? Incentives? Capability?
Why will customers use your product?	• What is your unique customer insight? • Is your product or service 10x better than alternatives? Why? • Why will they switch to you? What is the trigger point?
Advice	• Business that 100 users love > > Business that 1000 users like • Do not build a detailed feature list (focus on 2-3 key differentiators) • Build a fake MVP and sell to customers (you will get real feedback)

Why is my product 10x better than the alternatives?

Startup	Bad Example	Good Example
aws	AWS provides cloud infrastructure to startups.	AWS offers on-demand, scalable cloud infra - eliminating upfront costs and enabling rapid innovation compared traditional IT providers.
ditto	Ditto helps Indians buy insurance through tech-enabled advice.	Ditto simplifies buying with honest advice, no spam, and personalized, transparent support—putting customer needs before sales.

How much will my customers pay?

How will you price your product?	• What is the lower bound & upper bound? Costs, Competitors, Brand • How much money will you save for the customer? • How price-sensitive is the customer?
How many units will customers buy?	• Do they buy multiple units or a single unit? • Is this a one-time purchase or a recurring need? • Are there multiple customer segments with different usage rates?
Advice	• Do not use cost + pricing • How can you premiumize your product or service? (Utility + Brand) • What can you do to increase propensity to purchase?

How many customers can my startup serve?

How many people require your product?	• What is the total number of people that can use your product? • Consider both India and global markets
How many customers can you serve?	• How many people out there truly match your ideal customer profile? • What fraction of this segment can you capture?
Advice	• Do ground-up estimates and not top-down estimates • Good products change customer behavior and increase market size • Pressure test it using multiple data points

How many customers can my startup serve?

Startup	Bad Example	Good Example
sarvam.ai	$1.8T AI Market (McKinsey Research)	Top ~500-1000 companies that require Indian language customer support
Uber	Total number of people who hail cab services	It's the car ownership market, and not just ride hailing (good products expand market sizes)

Quick Note on Customer Interviews

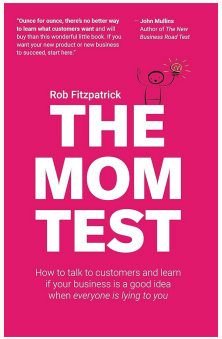
Do you face X problem?

If I make this product will you buy?

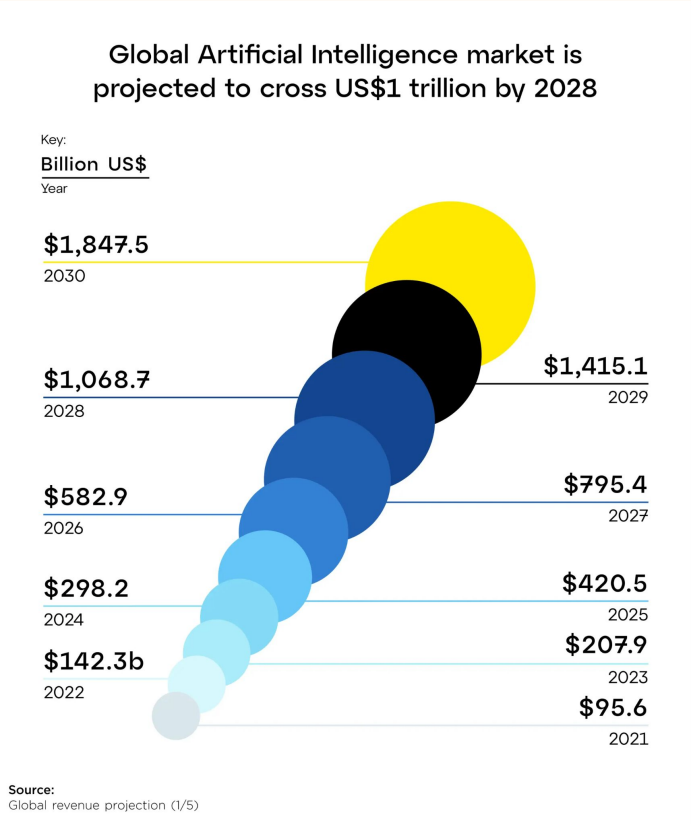
People Lie + They Don't Want to Hurt You

Conversation should be about the customer, their lives and problems

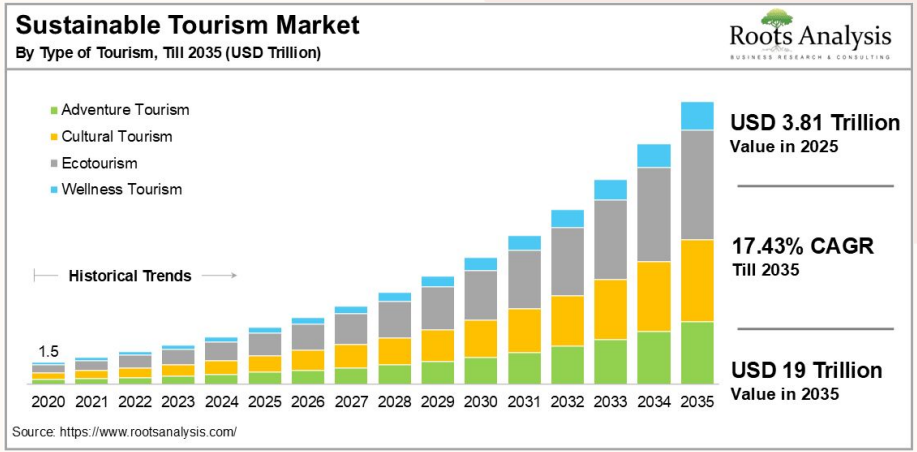
Beginning (Open Ended) → Keep Getting More Specific (Instances) + Ask Why



Do NOT Do Top Down Market Sizing



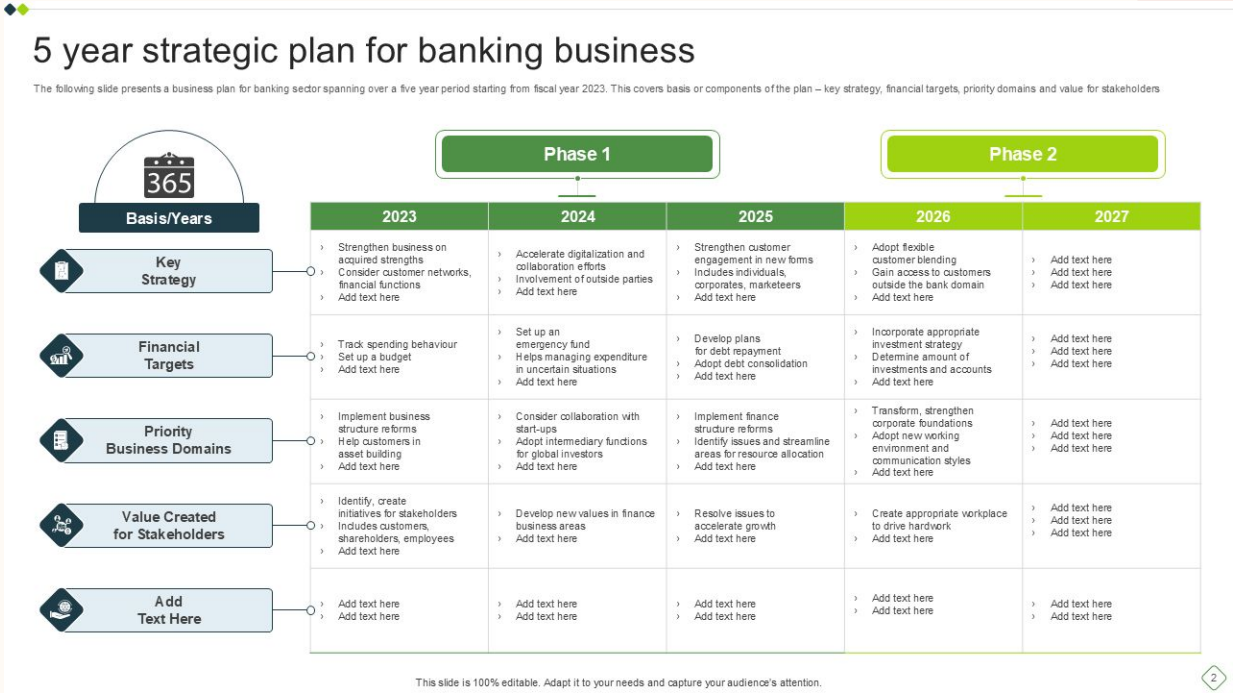
Source:
Global revenue projection (1/5)



Bottom Up

of ICP * Frequency * Pricing

No 5 Year or 12 Month Plans



Why am I the right founder? Why is this the right time?

Why are you the right founder founder to solve this problem?	• Do you have lived experience with this problem? • Why do you, specifically, care enough to outlast others? • Do you have an unfair advantage (skills, network, capital, tech)?
Why is the timing right?	• A recent shift (tech, regulation, behavior) now makes this possible • The cost to build or scale has dropped significantly • Cultural or generational trends are creating demand
Advice	• Choose spaces where your background, experience is an advantage • Build in a space you have real passion for

Why am I the right founder? Why is this the right time?

Startup	Bad Example	Good Example
OpenAI	Gen AI before GPUs & Transformer Paper would not have worked	Infra + Tech available since 2017 + Strong Technical Team with Massive Access to Capital
zepto	Quick Commerce would not have worked ~10-15 years back	High disposable income + high time value for money

Next Steps

Define Customer Pain Point	• Describe your ideal customer clearly with context and specific traits • Define their core pain point—when, why, and how it appears
Validate Pain Point with 5 Customers	• Is this a top 3-5 pain point? Why do current solutions fall short? • Are users solving this problem? How (time, energy, money?
Stress Test MVP in the Market	• Launch a mock landing page, drive traffic, test for sign-ups / orders • Offer a product version to early users for feedback and testimonials.
Assess Market Potential	• Estimate # of Users, Frequency of Use, and Willingness to Pay • Market potential: # of customers × frequency × price
Prove Founder-Market Fit	• Why you're uniquely positioned to solve this better than anyone else. • This could be skills, knowledge, networks, insights etc.

Surfer-Surfboard-Wave



All the best!

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